

THE PRACTICE

What does this achieve?

Humility, Openness, Insight

This practice is not about asserting control over words or ideas, but about fostering trust in the conversation itself—trust that when we mutually respect and listen to one another, something deeper than individual insight can emerge. We begin to practice patience, correct with gentleness, and leave space for personal growth leading to a greater understanding of truth.



Reveal insights we could not have had on our own.

No one controls the outcome. Instead, we trust in what can **emerge** when we listen together with empathy. The purposes of a person's heart are deep waters, and someone with patience can draw them out. This practice involves uncovering not just others' words, but the meaning beneath them, even those meanings hidden from ourselves. The structure might seem constraining, but it ultimately becomes liberating.

Light the spark

The structure of the practice is like bringing the kindling together for a fire. After one or two rounds the conversation will have found itself you can now move into a richer free flowing conversation with a sense of trust and fellowship.

Practice

Like learning a new song or skill this will feel “clunky” at first. You are training new muscles so be patient with yourselves and others. A musician needs to know their instrument well before they can perform melodies.

Part of an ecology

This practice is not meant to replace anything else or serve as a "silver bullet" to solve our problems. It should be integrated into our existing activities like discussion, learning, and communal gatherings so each can enrich and inform the others.

“I propose that [insert virtue] is...”

PROPOSER

Make sure you pause to let the listener reflect.

IT’S NOT WHAT YOU KNOW...

This is your chance to **explore** an idea; you don’t have to start with a perfectly formed thesis. You can start at the “wrong” place and feel your way towards what makes **more sense** to you.



To effectively share as the Speaker, follow these guidelines:

Practices like this often ask:
What is alive in you?

Regardless of the set topic, what is ‘**alive**’ might be something that happened yesterday, something about the environment you are in, or **anything else**. The practice is designed to **start broad** and circle in on what is most relevant to the group. What seems irrelevant might be the key to bringing the conversation ‘**find itself**.’

Listen to yourself

If you find you have nothing to say, you feel awkward or unsure of how you should start... this is exactly where you *should* start: let the listener repeat this back, see how it feels and what it give space for

Embrace Silence

Don’t feel pressured to fill silences. Pauses are a natural part of reflecting and processing; allow them to happen without rushing to speak.

Say it out loud.

Saying it out loud might be the start you need for the next most relevant thing to emerge. Even if it seems tangential or irrelevant, it's part of the exploration.

Boundaries

Share only what you're comfortable with, and avoid oversharing anything highly emotional when starting out. Respect yourself and others, and it's okay to pass if needed.

MIDWIFE

Ask the Proposer to pause intermittently so you can reflect.



IT’S NOT A TEST!

You don’t have to memorise everything. **Reflect back** what you can it will be useful for the speaker to understand what gets retained and might need emphasising. **Paraphrase** where needed.

To effectively listen, follow these guidelines:

Notice any need to direct the conversation with phrases like:

“That reminds me of...”

“But what about...”

“Don’t you think that actually...”

Avoiding these strengthens your active listening muscles!

Empty yourself

Refrain from offering advice or solutions. Let the speaker lead the direction of their thoughts. Don’t make it about you or your experiences.

Start with what you remember

Reflect back the most present thing you hear rather than everything in order. You often end up remembering the rest afterwards.

Be neutral

Listening does not mean agreeing, but equally try to put the listener at ease with your body language and tone. Reflect back without judgement.

Key Phrases:

“What I’m hearing you say is...”, “How does it feel to say this?”
“What would an example of this be in your life?”

SCRIBE

You will need a pen, paper & a timer/device.

IT'S NOT A TRANSCRIPT

You don't have to capture everything. Focus on the insights and themes that emerge naturally. Trust that what's most important will surface.



To effectively capture as the Scribe, follow these guidelines:

Use the Non-Verbal Prompt Sheet

If you notice the session is turning into a regular conversation or feel the speaker might need to give way to the listener tap the appropriate square on the sheet. You are also in charge of the timer try to give a 30 second warning.

Plot the flow

Note down where the speaker started, what they moved onto next and where they ended up.

What is unsaid

Notice any dynamics between the Speaker and Listener in terms of tone and body language. "At this point the speaker leant forward" "The listener mirrored uncrossing their arms"

Feedback

At the end of the round you will have a chance to briefly feedback on the flow of the Speaking and Listening and what unsaid things were noticed.

If you are the last Scribe from all the rounds, the group now moves into an unstructured free-flowing conversation having built up a sense of trust and shared understanding.

THE STRUCTURE

Check-In 2-3 mins total.

If necessary, briefly introduce yourselves and get comfortable. Perhaps state why you are here and what you hope to get out of the session.

Pick a theme and starting roles

The theme could be a passage, a virtue like patience or honesty, or an open inquiry into whatever is on each speaker's mind.

Set the timer.

The **Scribe** should keep the time. Pick a QR from below to start a timer.



2 min



3 min



5 min



Custom

3 Bells: Starting Bell, 30 Seconds Bell, Time Up Bell.

Feedback -3 mins total.

The **Scribe** feeds back after each round and the **Listener** states what they appreciated from what the **Speaker** said and also what they feel remains un-answered. This then sets up the next round where:

Listener becomes the **Speaker**.

Speaker becomes the **Scribe**.

Scribe becomes the **Listener**.

(A 4th rotating role of **Observer** can be added)

NON-VERBAL PROMPTS

**Slow
Down**

Take your time, there's
plenty of room for
your thoughts.

**Let the
Listener
respond**

**Let the
Speaker
direct
the flow**

**30
Seconds
Remaining**

Place in the centre to be pointed at without
breaking the flow of the session